

COMMUNICATION SKILLS

Written Communication Skills

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When to Put Something in Writing

- ❑ You discussed the issue before, but other parties either dismissed or overlooked what you thought were clear directions or mutual agreements.
- ❑ In this situation, you should document what you need done and make sure it is sent to the correct parties

Cont...

- You need to establish a policy or procedure. A written policy tends to carry more weight with employees than verbal instructions
- If something important has been misinterpreted, it might be necessary to clarify your instructions in writing
- An incident has occurred that increases risk for you or the organization.

Cont...

- Patient or employee accidents, medication errors, loud altercations, and disciplinary actions all increase the risk of litigation to you or the organization.
- Document these situations clearly, including only what you observed, not suppositions or assumptions
- When facts or agreements may be disputed later, write a memo to the record, or a memo documenting what was said, various parties' responsibilities, progress toward a goal, or the reasons why progress is less than expected

Cont...

- ❑ One of the most important points to remember in preparing any written communication is that if spelling or grammatical errors are present, they severely detract from the effectiveness of the message
- ❑ Grammatical and spelling errors
 - ✓ It is very tempting to rely on electronic spell checking and grammar checking devices because of their convenience, and these tools are quite useful.

Cont...

- ❑ Having a written “document of record” can have a greater impact than a simple conversation.
- ❑ A letter should include the following area:
 1. Statement of the problem.
 2. Potential solutions.
 3. Specific recommendations for the solution.
 4. Support for your recommendation.
 5. Description of follow-up.

Five Keys to Effective Writing

Key #1: Put the reader first

- Communication = understanding
- Write to Express not Impress
- Use words that readers can picture
- Tie into the reader's experience

Five Keys to Effective Writing

Key #2: Use simple words and short sentences

Avoid wordy prepositional phrases

- In the amount of (for)
- In order to (to)
- Due to the fact that (because)
- In the event that (if)
- During the time that (when, while)

Five Keys to Effective Writing

Key #3: Use jargon only when necessary

What is jargon?

- Specialist language that is used by a group, profession, or culture, especially when the words/phrases aren't understood or used by other people.

Five Keys to Effective Writing

Key #4: Write with verbs and nouns

- Use the active voice
- When it is okay to use passive voice

Five Keys to Effective Writing

Key #5: Format document to improve readability

- Use lists, bullets, charts, tables, indents, italics, bolds, headings and subheadings

Plan, Organize, Write

- **Before you begin writing : Think**

- Who is the audience (“My audience is_____.”)

- Purpose of the message (“My purpose is_____.”)

- How will the reader use the information (“So that the reader will_____.”)

Cont...

- **As you begin**
 - Assemble all useful information
 - Determine what's important
 - Choose what to leave out
 - Group information logically

Cont...

- **Four ways to organize**
 - Division
 - Compare/contrast
 - Cause/effect
 - Problem-analysis solution

Division

□ Start with main idea, then discuss the parts

Example:

- A X pharmaceutical corporation faces four problems that threaten its competitiveness:
 - ✓ Outdated marketing plan
 - ✓ Poor service record
 - ✓ High prices
 - ✓ Low Morale

Compare/Contrast

- Use familiar to explain unfamiliar
- Put the conclusion up front

Problem-Analysis-Solution

- **Find a straightforward way to offer recommendations.**

Example:

- ❖ The shipping dock's inability to ship product fast enough results from an inefficient tracking system. The solution is to:
 - Invest in a new computer system
 - Retrain staff
 - Inform customers of realistic shipping times
 - Budget for overtime to meet peak demand

Cause/Effect

- **Presents a clear-way analysis**

Example:

- ❖ Reorganizing the pharmaceutical marketing department will cause two benefits and one problem:
 - Improved accountability
 - Better communication
 - Problem – poorer service to industrial customers

Cont...

- **Develop an outline and then ...**

- Write the easiest part first
- Develop major sections one at a time
- Introduction for main ideas
- Main point in first paragraph
- Turn off your internal editor

Cont...

- 90% of writing is re-writing and editing
- Let the document cool
- Run a Fog test
- Aim to cut first draft by at least 10%

Note-Taking

- ❑ The process of note-taking can be done either in the form of paraphrasing or directly quoting the author's ideas.

1) Paraphrasing

- Refers to “restating or rewording a passage from a text, giving the same meaning in another form”
- The main objective of paraphrasing is to present an author's ideas in your own words

Cont...

2) Incorporating Direct Quotes

General principles of direct quotes:

- If your quotations are four lines in length or less (40 words or less), surround them with quotation marks and incorporate them into your text
- If your quotations are longer than four lines (40 words), set them off from the rest of the text by indenting five spaces from the left and right margins and triple-spacing above and below them.

Note-Taking Methods and Strategies

- First you must listen.
- Anticipate what is coming next.
- Focus on listening to what is being said.
- Taking notes keeps your mind active.
- Resist distractions.
- Involve yourself by thinking of examples as the speaker talks.
- Listen closely to introductory & closing remarks
- Pay attention to speaker cues...voice, physical motions, rate of speech

Cont...

- Note any material that is repeated
- Summarize the information to yourself
- Develop a personal shorthand...create a code

w/o without

b/c because

govt government

b/f before

imp important

cont continue

rt right

Cont...

- Do you ever assume you don't need to write anything down because you "heard it"??
 - Within 2 weeks you will forget 80% of what you heard.
 - Within 4 weeks you will remember only 5 % of what you heard.

Note Taking Methods

- **There are five methods of Note taking**

1. Cornell Note taking
2. Charting Method
3. Outlining
4. Mapping Method
5. Sentence Method

Cornell Note Taking Method

- **Description:** A systematic format of condensing and organizing notes without need for laborious recopying, by dividing paper into specific sections.
- **Method:** (R7 – Record, Recall, Reduce, Recapitulate, Recite, Review, Reflect).
- **Divide paper into three sections** (2-inch column on left - for “cues”; 6.5 inch “main space” on right –to make notes; 2-inch column on bottom to summarize.)

Cont...

- **When to use:**

- In **ANY lecture** situation

- **Advantages:**

- Provides an **organized** and **systematic** means for recording and reviewing notes
 - **Easy** format for pulling out major concepts and ideas
 - **Simple** and **efficient**
 - **Saves time** and effort
 - A “**Do-it-right-in-the-first-place**” method

- **Disadvantages:**

- **None**

Outline Method

- **Description:** Starting with general information at the left, with more specific facts and clarifications indented to the right
- **Method:**
 - Listen and then **write down points** in organized pattern, **based on space indentation**
 - Place **major points farthest to the left** and indent each **more specific point to the right**
 - Levels of **importance** will be indicated by **distance away from major point**
 - Indentation can be simple (no marking, just space relationships or more complex, by using Roman numerals, letters and/or decimals)

Cont...

- **When to use:**

- When **lecture is organized** and sequential
- There is enough **time** in lecture **to think** about and make organizational decisions

- **Advantages:**

- Well **organized system**, if done correctly
- Reduces need to edit
- Easy to turn **main points into questions**

Cont...

- **Disadvantages:**

- Requires more thought in class for accurate organization
- May not show relationships by sequence when needed
- Doesn't lend to itself to variety of review and question applications
- VERY difficult if lecturer speaks fast.

Mapping Method

- **Description:** A graphic means of representing information, which relates each fact/idea to every other fact or idea.
- **Method:**
 - Determine the “subject/topic”. Write this title in the center of page with a circle around it.
 - As your major facts (subheadings) are presented that relate to the subject/topic, draw lines out from the circle and label.

Cont...

- **When to use:**
 - When lecture **content** is **well organized**
 - Often effective with **guest lecturer** and have no idea how lecture will be presented
 - Effective if you are mainly a “**visual**” learner
- **Advantages:**
 - Helps keep **visual track** of lecture
 - **Relationships** easy to see
 - Can **cover lines** for memory **review** and relationships
- **Disadvantages:**
 - You may **not hear changes** in content from major points to facts
 - Can be **visually overwhelming**

Charting Method

- **Description:** A use of columns with appropriate heading labels in a table format i.e. material offered in chronological order
- **Method:**
 - Determine categories to be covered in lecture
 - Set paper up ahead of time by drawing columns with determined categories as headings for each
 - Place information in appropriate columns

Cont...

- **When to use:**
 - When test will focus on both **facts and relationships**
 - When you want an **overview** on one piece of paper in sequence
- **Advantages:**
 - **Reduces** amount of **writing** needed
 - Provides **easy review** mechanism
 - Facilitates both **memorization & comparison**
- **Disadvantages:**
 - Need to learn how to **develop effective categories**
 - Must be **fully engaged** in lecture

Sentence/Paragraphs

- **Description:** Record of complete thoughts/concepts.
- **Method:**
 - Write every new thought, fact or topic presented
 - Use a “new” line for each new thought/fact
 - Number lines as you progress

Cont...

- **When to use:**
 - When lecture is **somewhat organized**
 - **Heavy content** which comes **very fast**
 - Instructor **presents in point fashion**, but not in list i.e. “three related points”
- **Advantages:**
 - Gets **more** or **ALL** of **information**
- **Disadvantages:**
 - Can't determine major vs minor points from numbered sequence
 - **Difficult to edit** without having to totally rewrite.

Thank you !!